



The Rhine

Location From the Alps to the North Sea, central Europe

Second only to the Danube as the greatest river of west and central Europe, the Rhine rises from two headstreams (the Vorderrhein and the Hinterrein) high in the Swiss Alps and flows for 764 miles (1,230km). Along the way, it passes through Lake Constance (see p.373), the Upper Rhine graben (a block of crust that has moved

downward between two faults), the Rhine Gorge, and across the North German Plain before reaching its delta near Rotterdam. It is one of the most important arteries of industrial transport in the world.

The Seine

Location From Burgundy to the English Channel, northern France

France's second longest river has its source in the limestone hills

▲ THE RHINE WINDING THROUGH THE RUINAULTA CANYON

of Burgundy, from where it flows 483 miles (777km) northwest through the agricultural heartland of the Île de France region, then through Paris to the English Channel between Le Havre and Honfleur. The Seine carries most of France's inland waterway traffic, and canals link it to the Rhine (see left), Loire (see right), and Rhône (see p.372) navigations. The estuary experiences a bore, called the *mascaret*, when the highest tides send a surge of water sweeping upriver.

The Loire

Location From the Massif Central to the Bay of Biscay, France

The longest river in France rises from three springs near the base of Mont Gerbier de Jonc, a lava dome in the Massif Central. The Loire flows north to the Orleans region, where it swings to the west, eventually discharging via a tidal estuary into the Bay of Biscay. It is 629 miles (1,012km) long, and drains more than 20 percent of France.